The Last Mile Shared Mobility Manifesto

‘The Last Mile Shared Car’: A new vision for mobility

Preamble

The car is a marvellous means of transport. Since the late 19th century, it has gradually paved the way for unrivalled freedom of movement; it has been the driving force behind cutting-edge technological innovations; it has fuelled our dreams and boosted our egos to the skies.

Our cities, our infrastructure and our societies have been built around the car. Our lives are organised outside city centres, and sometimes far from our homes. But as the population grows, our dependence on the car is producing an effect that runs counter to our original aspiration for freedom: congestion in city centres and on road networks is a daily reality for many car owners.

However, many cars are rarely used. The majority of journeys carry just one person[1] to a nearby destination such as an office or a public transport hub. These journeys do not reflect the sense of pleasure or adventure that first made us love the car.

The question therefore needs to be asked:

Should the freedom to get about still depend on owning a vehicle?

We believe not. The 21st century must redefine mobility.

Every era invents the infrastructure that suits its time, the available technologies and humanity’s vision of progress. The railway connected cities. Air travel connected countries. The telephone connected people.

Our era gives us the opportunity to invent the mobility of tomorrow:

- Autonomous driving technology has reached a sufficient level of maturity for real-world, supervised roll-outs in urban and suburban areas at moderate speeds.
- Local authorities are seeking credible mobility solutions to reduce dependence on private cars, without the costs of major infrastructure projects.
- Users are becoming increasingly familiar with on-demand services (private hire vehicles, car-sharing, delivery) — usage precedes technology.

So, let’s redefine mobility.

[1] Mobility of people | Data and statistical studies (in French)

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I. Mobility is a need. The car is one possible solution.

For decades, owning a car has been the best way to meet a universal and legitimate need: to move about freely.

Today, this model is revealing its limitations within the context of our societies:

- A car represents a significant investment for a household, and the associated recurring costs have a major impact on our quality of life
- It takes up a considerable amount of space in our towns and cities, in our car parks and on our roads, causing the phenomenon known as ‘road congestion’
- It remains stationary for most of its lifetime, and most often carries just one person, despite its increasing size

We have made car ownership a prerequisite for our mobility, and a source of congestion. But the car is not the problem, and our aim is not to do away with it. The problem lies in how it is used. This needs to be reviewed and optimised.

Our aim is to reorganise car use in such a way as to increase its utilisation rate. In the future, the car could become a shared service rather than an asset sitting idle outside every home.

We propose to separate the concepts of ownership and mobility.

II. From ownership to access, for greater freedom

We have already experienced this transformation through small changes in our habits, always leading to greater simplicity and new possibilities:

- We no longer buy the films we watch
- We no longer buy the software we use
- We no longer buy the servers that host our photos and data

We access services.

Mobility must follow the same path. The aim is no longer to own a vehicle; the aim is to have access to mobility at any time, more easily, thereby broadening the range of possibilities:

- An elderly person regains their independence
- A teenager can get to their activities more easily
- A family can do without a second car
- A local authority reclaims space currently used for parking
- Everyone has easier access to public transport

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Mobility becomes simpler because it is organised collectively, whilst remaining an individual experience.

We do not claim that technology alone solves car dependency. We are not replacing walking, cycling or public transport itself — we are enhancing them by removing their main sticking point.

III. The missing link

Public transport forms the backbone of sustainable mobility:

- It is fast
- It is fuel-efficient
- It is efficient

Yet one obstacle remains:

How can people easily get to a train station, tram stop or bus stop from their homes?

That first kilometre — and its counterpart, the last — still mean that millions of people have to own a car.

Solving this problem will change the whole equation.

We propose treating the first and last kilometres as public transport infrastructure. We propose integrating this infrastructure with the existing public transport network.

A fleet of autonomous, shared electric vehicles serves, on demand, every neighbourhood, every home and every office block. It connects residents to transport hubs:

- Trains, trams and buses cover long distances
- Shared vehicles cover short distances

Each mode is used where it is most efficient: competition gives way to complementarity.

IV. What sets us apart

We will avoid using new technologies to replicate the congestion we currently experience. That is not the aim. Autonomous ‘first/last kilometre’ transport already exists — in the form of fixed-route shuttles, operated by local authorities in pilot areas (Atlanta, Tampa, Contra Costa, etc.). These projects have demonstrated the technical viability and value of the concept. We aim to harness technology to serve a new model of mobility.

This is a paradigm shift.

Autonomous vehicles are not an end in themselves: they are a means to an end.

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Technological progress is most meaningful when it enables us to make better use of existing resources. Our proposal is in line with this approach:

- Fewer vehicles
- Greater mobility
- Greater freedom

Nor do we ignore the issues raised by autonomous vehicles: safety, social acceptance, the regulatory framework and the impact on drivers' jobs. These are issues we wish to address in collaboration with local authorities.

V. Our ambition

Mobility is an ecosystem; it can only evolve collectively, by involving all stakeholders. This transformation can only succeed if it brings together players who currently work separately:

- Local authorities
- Transport operators
- Manufacturers
- Researchers
- Urban planners
- Citizens

We are creating an open and collaborative project in which every partner, sponsor and project proponent will be able to contribute and share their vision and expectations.

Conclusion

The 20th century made the car accessible to all. The 21st century must make mobility accessible to all.

We envisage communities where car ownership is no longer a necessity. Cities where car parks are transformed into cultural spaces, schools, gardens or public squares. Areas where everyone can get about, regardless of their age, income or physical ability.

This is not a break with the past, but the next step in the ongoing process of progress. It is a society where every home is naturally connected to the transport network, where mobility no longer depends on car ownership, and where technology serves people, giving them back time, space and freedom.

Mobility is a necessity.

Car ownership may no longer be the best solution.

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